WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 1

The LORD Comes Down

Micah 1:1–16

TO GET STARTED

Think of a place you felt completely safe as a child – a room, a house, a tree. What made it feel so safe?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Micah was a man from the countryside, from the farming village of Moresheth-gath in the Shephelah, the hilly lowlands south-west of Jerusalem. He prophesied under Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah (about 740–686 BC), while Assyria swallowed up the nations, the elite in Samaria and Jerusalem grew rich, and ordinary smallholders paid the price. His name is itself a question – who is like the LORD? – and it is the question that runs through this whole series. Tonight we read chapter 1: God comes down to judge Samaria (vv. 1–7), and Micah laments as the disaster reaches his own home towns and the gate of Jerusalem (vv. 8–16).

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:1–2

1 The word of the LORD that came to Micah of Moresheth in the days of Jotham, Ahaz
and Hezekiah, kings of Judah, which he saw concerning Samaria and Jerusalem.

2 Hear, you peoples, all of you!
Listen, O earth, and all that fills it!
Let the Lord, the LORD, be a witness against you,
the Lord from his holy temple.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:3–4

3 For look: the LORD is coming out of his place;
he comes down and treads on the high places of the earth.
4 The mountains melt beneath him,
and the valleys split open,
like wax before the fire,
like water poured down a slope.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:5–5

5 All this is for the rebellion of Jacob
and for the sins of the house of Israel.
What is the rebellion of Jacob?
Is it not Samaria?
And what are the high places of Judah?
Is it not Jerusalem?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:6–6

6 So I will make Samaria a heap of rubble in the open field,
a place for planting vineyards;
I will pour her stones down into the valley
and lay bare her foundations.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:7–7

7 All her carved images will be smashed,
all her wages will be burned with fire,
and all her idols I will make a desolation;
for from the wages of a prostitute she gathered them,
and to the wages of a prostitute they will return.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:8–8

8 Because of this I will lament and wail;
I will go stripped and naked;
I will make a lament like the jackals
and a mourning like the ostriches.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:9–9

9 For her wounds are incurable;
it has come as far as Judah,
it has reached the gate of my people,
as far as Jerusalem.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:10–10

10 In Gath do not tell it;
do not weep at all.
In Beth-leaphrah
roll yourself in the dust.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:11–11

11 Pass on your way,
inhabitant of Shaphir, in nakedness and shame.
The inhabitant of Zaanan
has not come out.
The lament of Beth-ezel –
it will take from you its standing place.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:12–12

12 For the inhabitant of Maroth
waits in anguish for good,
for evil has come down from the LORD
to the gate of Jerusalem.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:13–13

13 Harness the chariot to the steed,
inhabitant of Lachish!
She was the beginning of sin for Daughter Zion,
for in you were found the rebellions of Israel.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:14–14

14 Therefore you will give parting gifts
to Moresheth-gath;
the houses of Achzib will be a deceit
to the kings of Israel.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:15–15

15 Once more I will bring the one who takes possession to you,
inhabitant of Mareshah;
as far as Adullam
the glory of Israel will come.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 1:16–16

16 Make yourself bald and shave your head
for the children of your delight;
make your baldness as wide as the vulture's,
for they have gone from you into exile.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

שִׁמְעוּ

shim'u · "Hear"

The first word of 1:2 is a summons into court: "Hear, you peoples, all of you!" The same call opens each of the book's three main sections (1:2; 3:1; 6:1). The Lord, the LORD, is not only judge here but also the witness against his own people.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

בָּמוֹת

bamot · "high places"

The LORD "treads on the high places of the earth" (1:3) – the peaks and strongholds people trust in. But bamot are also the pagan shrines on the hills. So Micah asks with irony: "And what are the high places of Judah? Is it not Jerusalem?" (1:5).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

אַכְזָב

akhzav · “deceit”

In 1:10–15 Micah plays on the names of the towns around his home. Achzib sounds like akhzav, a brook that dries up in the drought: “the houses of Achzib will be a deceit to the kings of Israel” (1:14) – an empty promise just when the thirst is greatest.

THE BIG IDEA

When the holy God comes down, every false "high place" we trust in melts like wax – and the prophet who sees it coming does not gloat, but weeps for his own people.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Micah opens not with gentle encouragement but with a court summons to the whole earth. What does it tell you about God that he comes down “from his holy temple” to deal with his people?

Micah 1:2–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“What is the rebellion of Jacob? Is it not Samaria? And what are the high places of Judah? Is it not Jerusalem?” Why does spiritual decay so often begin at the centres of influence – and what does that mean for leaders today, including in the church?

Micah 1:5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

A “high place” is anything we run to for comfort, identity and safety instead of the living God. What are the “high places” of our culture? Which of them tempt you most?

Micah 1:3–7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Before Micah speaks a single word about his own region, he says: “Because of this I will lament and wail.” What is the difference between a critic and a prophet? How do you usually react to the brokenness you see around you?

Micah 1:8–9

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Judah thought Samaria's judgement would stop at the border. But “it has reached the gate of my people”. Where do we allow a “small compromise” at the edges of our life, thinking it will never reach the centre?

Micah 1:9–12

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Lachish trusted in its chariots: “She was the beginning of sin for Daughter Zion.” What is your “Lachish” – a good gift you have slowly begun to trust instead of the Lord?

Micah 1:13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Have you ever had an earthly security let you down like Achzib, the brook that dries up? How did God meet you in that disappointment? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

Micah 1:14–16

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one “high place” in your life (work, money, approval, your own cleverness) and each day this week tell God in a short prayer that you trust him more than it.
- Choose one situation in your community, church or country that you usually criticise, and this week pray for it with compassion instead – at least three times.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray in pairs or threes: thank God that he is holy and comes down to set things right, and ask him to break down the “high places” each person named. Then pray for your own town or country as Micah lamented for his – with tears rather than stones.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 2

Greed and the Breaker

Micah 2:1–13

TO GET STARTED

Which advert, slogan or jingle from your childhood can you still recite – and what did it promise you?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapter 1 Micah exposed Judah's relationship with God: idols and false securities. Now he turns to how they treat their neighbours. In Israel every family's land was an inheritance, a gift from the LORD that guaranteed its freedom and bread (Leviticus 25:23; 1 Kings 21:3). But in the eighth century BC a wealthy elite used debts, bribed courts and sheer power to take the smallholders' fields. Tonight we read the woe over the land-grabbers (vv. 1–5), Micah's clash with the preachers who want him silenced (vv. 6–11), and a sudden promise: the LORD gathers his flock and the Breaker goes before them (vv. 12–13).

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:1–1

[1] Woe to those who devise wickedness
and work evil on their beds!
In the light of morning they carry it out,
because it is in the power of their hand.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:2–2

2 They covet fields and seize them,
and houses, and take them away;
they oppress a man and his house,
a person and his inheritance.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:3–3

3 Therefore thus says the LORD:
Look, against this family I am devising evil,
from which you cannot remove your necks;
and you will not walk with heads held high,
for it will be a time of evil.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:4–4

4 On that day they will take up a taunt-song against you
and wail a bitter lament:
"It is done!" one says.
"We are utterly ruined!
He exchanges the portion of my people.
How he takes it away from me!
To the renegade he divides up our fields."

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:5–6

5 Therefore you will have no one
to cast the measuring line by lot
in the assembly of the LORD.
6 "Do not preach!" – so they preach.
"One should not preach about such things;
disgrace will not overtake us."

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:7–7

7 Should this be said, house of Jacob:
"Is the Spirit of the LORD impatient?
Are these his deeds?"
Do my words not do good
to the one who walks uprightly?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:8–8

8 But lately my people has risen up as an enemy.
From off the garment you strip the cloak
from those who pass by in trust,
like men coming home from war.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:9–9

9 The women of my people you drive out,
each from the house she delights in;
from her little children you take away
my splendour for ever.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:10–10

10 Get up and go!
For this is not the resting place;
because of uncleanness it brings destruction,
a grievous destruction.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:11–11

11 If a man came walking in wind and falsehood
and lied: "I will preach to you about wine and strong drink!" –
he would be the preacher for this people.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:12–12

12 I will surely gather all of you, Jacob;
I will surely assemble the remnant of Israel.
I will put them together like sheep in a fold,
like a flock in the midst of its pasture;
they will be noisy with people.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 2:13–13

13 The one who breaks open goes up before them;
they break through, pass through the gate
and go out by it.
Their king passes on before them,
and the LORD at their head.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חָמַד

chamad · “covet”

“They covet fields and seize them” (2:2). Chamad is the word of the Tenth Commandment (Exodus 20:17). What begins as a quiet desire on the bed at night ends at daybreak in gazal – seizing by force.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חָשַׁב

chashav · “devise”

The oppressors lie on their beds and devise wickedness (2:1). The LORD answers with the same verb: “Look, against this family I am devising evil” (2:3). The schemers run headlong into the one who plans the history of the world.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

הַפֹּרֵץ

haporets · "the one who breaks open"

From parats, to break a gap in a wall. The flock is shut in like sheep in a fold, but "The one who breaks open goes up before them" (2:13), and their king and the LORD lead the way out. The devotional sees its full meaning in Christ, the Good Shepherd (John 10).

THE BIG IDEA

God sees the schemes we devise at night and the power we use against the weak, he will not be silenced by soothing preachers – and yet he himself goes ahead of his people as the one who breaks open the way.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“Woe to those who devise wickedness and work evil on their beds!” What do your thoughts usually turn over in the quiet hours of the night? Why does Micah start with the bed and not with the deed?

Micah 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Because it is in the power of their hand” – the word for power (el) is the same as the word for God, so one can also hear it as: their hand is a god to them. Where do you have power or leverage over others (work, money, home), and how do you use it?

Micah 2:1–2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

For the greedy it is about “fields” and “houses”; God sees “a man and his house, a person and his inheritance”. Where are people today treated as things in the name of profit – and where are we part of it?

Micah 2:2–5

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The opponents say: “One should not preach about such things; disgrace will not overtake us.” Why do we so easily prefer comfortable voices – the preacher of “wine and strong drink” – to the truth that heals?

Micah 2:6–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Do my words not do good to the one who walks uprightly?” How do you react inwardly when a passage of Scripture or a friend puts a finger on a sore spot in your life?

Micah 2:7

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“From her little children you take away my splendour for ever.” How does injustice against families rob the next generation? Who are the vulnerable people around you whose dignity needs protecting?

Micah 2:8–10

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“The one who breaks open goes up before them.” What wall of fear, failure or impossibility are you facing right now – and what would it mean to follow the King who goes ahead of you?

Micah 2:12–13

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Look at one area where the power is in your hand (as an employer, parent, customer or neighbour) and do one concrete thing this week that protects the dignity of someone weaker.
- Before going to sleep each night, give your thoughts of the day to God in a short prayer – especially any envy or resentment – instead of turning them over in bed.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray together: ask God to cleanse the secret rooms of our thoughts and to make us content with the inheritance he has given us in Christ. Pray for people in your area who are losing home, land or work. Then thank Jesus, the Breaker, for going ahead of each person into the situation they named.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 3

Filled with Power

Micah 3:1–12

TO GET STARTED

Who is someone you have known – a teacher, a boss, a coach – whose leadership made you better? What did they do?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

With “Hear, please” chapter 3 begins a new series of oracles. Micah now walks into the highest seats of power in Jerusalem: the heads and rulers who should guard justice at the city gate (vv. 1–4), and the prophets who should be the nation's conscience but sell their voices (vv. 5–7). Over against them stands Micah's own confession: “But as for me, I am filled with power” (v. 8). The chapter ends with a word that seemed unthinkable: Zion ploughed like a field (v. 12). More than a hundred years later Jeremiah 26:17–19 recalls that King Hezekiah heard this word, humbled himself, and the LORD held back the disaster.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:1–1

[1] And I said:
Hear, please, you heads of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel!
Is it not for you to know justice?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:2–2

2 You who hate good and love evil,
who tear their skin from off them
and their flesh from off their bones;

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:3–3

3 who eat the flesh of my people
and strip their skin from off them,
break their bones in pieces
and chop them up like meat for the pot,
like flesh in the cauldron.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:4–4

4 Then they will cry out to the LORD,
but he will not answer them;
he will hide his face from them at that time,
because they have made their deeds evil.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:5–5

5 Thus says the LORD concerning the prophets
who lead my people astray,
who, when they have something to bite with their teeth,
call out "Peace!",
but whoever puts nothing into their mouths,
against him they sanctify war:

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:6–6

6 Therefore it will be night for you, without vision,
and darkness for you, without divination.
The sun will go down on the prophets,
and the day will grow dark over them.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:7–7

7 The seers will be ashamed
and the diviners disgraced;
they will all cover their lips,
for there is no answer from God.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:8–8

8 But as for me, I am filled with power,
with the Spirit of the LORD,
with justice and with might,
to declare to Jacob his rebellion
and to Israel his sin.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:9–10

9 Hear this, please, you heads of the house of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel,
who abhor justice
and twist everything that is straight,
10 who build Zion with blood
and Jerusalem with injustice!

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:11–11

11 Her heads judge for a bribe,
her priests teach for a price,
and her prophets divine for money;
yet they lean on the LORD and say:
"Is not the LORD in our midst?
No evil will come upon us."

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 3:12–12

12 Therefore, because of you,
Zion will be ploughed as a field,
Jerusalem will become heaps of ruins,
and the mountain of the house a wooded height.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מִשְׁפָּט

mishpat · "justice"

"Is it not for you to know justice?" (3:1). To "know" (yada') means a lived commitment, not just knowledge of the law. The leaders "abhor justice" (3:9) – but Micah is filled "with justice and with might" (3:8).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

נָשַׁךְ

nashakh · “bite”

The prophets cry “Peace!” when they have “something to bite with their teeth” (3:5). Nashakh is used for the bite of a snake (Numbers 21:6), and from the same root comes neshekh, usury. Whoever pays nothing finds holy language turned against him: “against him they sanctify war”.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

שָׁעַן

sha'an · "lean"

Heads, priests and prophets all work for money, "yet they lean on the LORD" (3:11) – they put their full weight on God's promises like a staff, as a religious crutch, while living in open disobedience: "Is not the LORD in our midst?"

THE BIG IDEA

God holds leaders, judges and preachers to account for how they treat his people, and he will not be bribed by pious slogans – but he fills those who rely on his Spirit with power, justice and might to speak the truth.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“Is it not for you to know justice?” Micah uses shocking butcher language for the leaders (vv. 2–3). Why does God use such raw images for what looked like tidy bookkeeping and court orders?

Micah 3:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Then they will cry out to the LORD, but he will not answer them.” How can the way we treat people stand between us and God in prayer? Is there a relationship you need to put right?

Micah 3:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The prophets proclaim “Peace!” to those who feed them and declare war on those who don't. Where do we show friendliness mainly to people who can give us something back – and how do we treat those who can't?

Micah 3:5–7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the LORD, with justice and with might.” Micah had no royal backing or family connections. In which situation do you need the Spirit's power, justice and might to speak or act rightly?

Micah 3:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

They “twist everything that is straight” and “build Zion with blood”. What are you building your career, finances or family life with? Where are we tempted to bend what is straight just a little?

Micah 3:9–10

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Is not the LORD in our midst? No evil will come upon us.” How can church habits and Christian slogans become a crutch that lets us carry on with something God disapproves of?

Micah 3:11

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Hezekiah heard 3:12 and humbled himself (Jeremiah 26:17–19). Looking back over Micah 1–3, what one concrete change is the Lord calling you to make?

Micah 3:12

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of one person under your authority or in a service role around you (a colleague, a cashier, a child) and this week do something to build up their dignity – without expecting anything back.
- Pick one situation this week where you are tempted to keep quiet or bend the truth; before it, pray for the Spirit's power, and then speak or act with gentleness but without compromise.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray together for the Holy Spirit to fill each of you with power, justice and might for the situations you named. Confess where we have leaned on religious habits instead of obeying. Then pray for leaders – in government, business and the church – that they may know justice and protect the weak.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 4

Swords into Ploughshares

Micah 4:1–14

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever turned something broken or useless into something useful – an old tool, a piece of furniture, a pair of worn-out jeans? What did you make of it?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 3 ended with a heap of ruins: because of Judah's corrupt leaders, Zion would be ploughed like a field and the temple mount overgrown with scrub. Chapter 4 suddenly opens with “And it will come to pass in the last days” – a vision found almost word for word in Isaiah 2:2–4. Then three scenes (“On that day”, “Now”, “And now”) lead along the hard road of exile to Babylon, and the chapter ends in 4:14 (English 5:1) with Jerusalem under siege and her judge struck on the cheek.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:1–1

[1] And it will come to pass in the last days
that the mountain of the house of the LORD
will stand firm as the highest of the mountains
and be lifted up above the hills,
and peoples will stream to it.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:2–2

2 Many nations will come and say:
"Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob,
so that he may teach us his ways
and we may walk in his paths."
For from Zion instruction will go out,
and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:3–3

3 He will judge between many peoples
and settle disputes for mighty nations far away.
They will beat their swords into ploughshares
and their spears into pruning knives.
Nation will not lift up sword against nation,
and they will no longer learn war.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:4–4

4 They will sit, each under his vine
and under his fig tree,
and no one will make them afraid;
for the mouth of the LORD of hosts has spoken.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:5–5

5 For all the peoples walk,
each in the name of its god,
but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God
for ever and ever.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:6–6

6 On that day – declares the LORD –
I will gather the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and the one on whom I brought evil.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:7–7

7 I will make the lame a remnant,
and the one driven far away a mighty nation;
and the LORD will reign over them on Mount Zion
from now on and for ever.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:8–8

8 And you, tower of the flock,
hill of Daughter Zion,
to you it will come:
the former dominion will come,
the kingdom of Daughter Jerusalem.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:9–9

9 Now, why do you cry out so loudly?
Is there no king in you?
Has your counsellor perished,
that pain has seized you like a woman giving birth?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:10–10

10 Writhe and push, Daughter Zion,
like a woman giving birth!
For now you will go out of the city
and live in the open field;
you will come as far as Babylon.
There you will be rescued;
there the LORD will redeem you
from the hand of your enemies.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:11–11

11 And now many nations
have gathered against you,
who say: "Let her be defiled,
and let our eyes gloat over Zion!"

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:12–12

12 But they do not know the plans of the LORD,
and they do not understand his counsel:
that he has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:13–13

13 Get up and thresh, Daughter Zion!
For I will make your horn iron,
and your hoofs I will make bronze;
you will crush many peoples.
And I will devote their gain to the LORD,
their wealth to the Lord of all the earth.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 4:14–14

14 Now gather your troops, daughter of troops!
A siege has been laid against us;
with the staff they strike the judge of Israel
on the cheek. (*English Bibles*: 5:1)

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְנָהֲרוּ

wenaharu · “will stream”

The verb comes from nahar, “river”: the peoples will flow like a mighty river (4:1). But water flows downhill – here the nations flow uphill, up the mountain of the LORD. The pull of God's grace is stronger than the gravity of human selfishness and division.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

הַצֹּלֵעָה

hatstsole'ah · “the lame”

The verb tsala' is used of Jacob limping after he wrestled with God (Genesis 32:31, Hebrew 32:32). A human leader builds a nation from the strongest; the LORD says, “I will make the lame a remnant” (4:7). Weakness is not a disqualification but the place where his power is seen.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חוּלִי וָגֹחִי

chuli wagochi · “writhe and push”

In 4:9–10 Jerusalem screams in terror, and Micah compares her pain to that of a woman giving birth (kayyoledah). Death throes end in a grave; birth pains, however fierce, bring forth new life – “There you will be rescued; there the LORD will redeem you” (4:10).

THE BIG IDEA

Judgement is not God's last word: the mountain left in ruins becomes the mountain the nations stream to, and on the hard road through exile the LORD gathers the lame, turns his people's pain into birth pains and rules even over the plans of their enemies.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

At the end of chapter 3 the temple mount lies in ruins; in 4:1 the same mountain “will stand firm as the highest of the mountains”. What does this sudden turn tell us about God's judgement and his purposes?

Micah 4:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

The nations say: “Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD, to the house of the God of Jacob, so that he may teach us his ways and we may walk in his paths.” What draws them – force or longing? Do you come to God's word with that kind of hunger?

Micah 4:2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Notice the order in verses 2–3: first instruction goes out from Zion and the LORD judges, and only then are swords beaten into ploughshares. Why can't lasting peace come before that? What “swords and spears” (sarcasm, old grudges, harsh words) might God want to reforge in your relationships?

Micah 4:2–3

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Each person sits under his vine and fig tree, “and no one will make them afraid” – while in 2:1–2 the powerful seized the small farmers' fields. Verse 5 then says: “but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God for ever and ever.” Where does the culture around you invite you to walk in the name of other “gods”?

Micah 4:4–5

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The LORD gathers the lame, the outcast and “the one on whom I brought evil”, and then says: “I will make the lame a remnant.” Why would God build his future with people like that? What does this mean for someone who feels limping or second-rate?

Micah 4:6–7

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Is there no king in you? Has your counsellor perished, that pain has seized you like a woman giving birth?” The nations gather to destroy Zion, “But they do not know the plans of the LORD”. Looking back, can you name a crisis that turned out to be birth pains rather than death throes?

Micah 4:9–12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The chapter ends with a siege: “with the staff they strike the judge of Israel on the cheek” (4:14; English 5:1). When our own leaders, plans and strength are humiliated like this, where can hope still come from? (Leave the answer open for next week.)

Micah 4:14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one “sword” in your speech or attitude towards a particular person and turn it into a “ploughshare” this week: one honest, kind word or act that builds up instead of cutting down.
- Read 4:1–5 each morning this week and pray for one place in the world (or one relationship) where there is war, asking that the word of the LORD would bring peace there.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together that his judgement never has the last word. Let each person pray, silently or aloud, for one area where they feel “lame” or under pressure, and ask the LORD to gather and use it. Close by praying verse 5 together as a commitment: we will walk in the name of the LORD our God.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 5

The Ruler from Bethlehem

Micah 5:1–14

TO GET STARTED

Think of a small, unremarkable place – a village, a school, a corner shop, a kitchen table – that turned out to matter a great deal in your life. What made it so important?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Last week ended with Jerusalem besieged and her judge struck on the cheek (4:14; English 5:1). Now God turns our eyes to a village less than ten kilometres south of Jerusalem: Bethlehem Ephrathah, where David was once called as a shepherd boy. Centuries later the scribes quote this very verse to Herod (Matthew 2:6). The chapter then shows how God's people live under this Shepherd: as dew and as a lion among the nations, and cleansed of everything they trusted instead of him. (Our verse numbers are Hebrew: in English Bibles add one throughout this chapter.)

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:1–1

[1] But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,
too small to be among the clans of Judah,
from you one will come out for me
to be ruler in Israel;
his origins are from of old,
from ancient days. (*English Bibles*: 5:2; *from here on add one to the verse number*)

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:2–2

2 Therefore he will give them up
until the time when she who is in labour has given birth;
then the rest of his brothers will return
to the children of Israel.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:3–3

3 He will stand and shepherd
in the strength of the LORD,
in the majesty of the name of the LORD his God.
And they will dwell secure,
for now he will be great
to the ends of the earth.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:4–4

4 And this one will be peace.
When Assyria comes into our land
and when he treads in our fortresses,
we will raise against him seven shepherds
and eight princes of men.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:5–5

5 They will shepherd the land of Assyria with the sword,
and the land of Nimrod at its gates.
And he will rescue us from Assyria
when he comes into our land
and when he treads within our borders.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:6–6

6 And the remnant of Jacob will be
in the midst of many peoples
like dew from the LORD,
like showers on the grass,
which does not wait for a man
nor hope for the children of men.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:7–7

7 And the remnant of Jacob will be among the nations,
in the midst of many peoples,
like a lion among the animals of the forest,
like a young lion among the flocks of sheep,
which, if it passes through, tramples and tears,
and there is no one to rescue.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:8–9

8 Your hand will be lifted high over your adversaries,
and all your enemies will be cut off.
9 And it will come to pass on that day – declares the LORD –
that I will cut off your horses from among you
and make your chariots perish.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:10–11

10 I will cut off the cities of your land
and tear down all your fortresses.
11 I will cut off sorceries from your hand,
and you will have no more fortune-tellers.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:12–13

12 I will cut off your carved images
and your sacred pillars from among you,
and you will no longer bow down
to the work of your hands.
13 I will uproot your Asherah poles from among you
and destroy your cities.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 5:14–14

14 And in anger and in wrath I will execute vengeance
on the nations that did not listen.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מִימֵי עוֹלָם

mimei 'olam · "from ancient days"

The word 'olam can mean "the distant past" but also "eternity". Our translation reads "his origins are from of old, from ancient days" (5:1; English 5:2), yet the phrase can just as well mean 'from the days of eternity'. Day 9 hears both: his roots lie in the ancient promise to David, and his origin reaches back before creation (cf. John 1:1–2).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְהָיָה זֶה שָׁלוֹם

wehayah zeh shalom · “and this one will be peace”

The text does not merely say that the Ruler will bring peace or make peace. Literally it says: “And this one will be peace.” (5:4; English 5:5). This One (zeh) is himself the peace – peace is not a treaty but a Person (cf. Ephesians 2:14).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְהִכְרַתִּי

wehikhratti · “I will cut off”

Four times in 5:9–12 (English 5:10–13) the LORD says “I will cut off” – horses and chariots, cities and fortresses, sorceries, carved images and sacred pillars – and then “I will uproot” the Asherah poles (5:13, English 5:14) – wooden cult poles or stylised sacred trees beside the altars, linked with the goddess Asherah. It is the verb for cutting a covenant and for cutting down a tree: God's surgeon's knife removes every crutch that keeps his people from leaning on him.

THE BIG IDEA

Out of little Bethlehem God brings a Ruler whose origins reach back to ancient days, who stands and shepherds in the strength of the LORD and is himself our peace – and under him his people become dew and lion among the nations, while he cuts away every false support they lean on.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

After the humiliated judge of 4:14 comes: “But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, too small to be among the clans of Judah” (5:1; English 5:2). Why does God go back to David's humble roots instead of the palace in Jerusalem? Where in your life do you feel “too small” to matter?

Micah 5:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“His origins are from of old, from ancient days.” What does the double meaning of 'olam (the distant past, or eternity) suggest about who this Ruler is? How does Matthew 2:1–6 help us read the verse?

Micah 5:1

DISCUSSION · 3/7

God gives his people up “until the time when she who is in labour has given birth” (5:2; English 5:3). How do we live faithfully in seasons when God's promise seems a long way off?

Micah 5:2

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“He will stand and shepherd in the strength of the LORD … And they will dwell secure” (5:3; English 5:4). Compare this Shepherd with the leaders of chapter 3 who devoured the flock. Are you trying to keep watch yourself through worry and control, instead of resting while he stands?

Micah 5:3

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“And this one will be peace.” (5:4; English 5:5). What is your inner peace built on at the moment – on circumstances going well, or on the Person of Christ? What difference does it make that peace is a Person?

Micah 5:4

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The remnant of Jacob will be “like dew from the LORD, like showers on the grass”, which waits for no human being – and also “like a lion among the animals of the forest” (5:6–7; English 5:7–8). Where do you need to be more like dew (quiet, refreshing, gracious), and where more like the lion (brave and unbending before evil)?

Micah 5:6–7

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The LORD cuts off horses, fortresses, sorceries and images, “and you will no longer bow down to the work of your hands” (5:12; English 5:13). What are today's “horses and fortresses” – savings, expertise, status, control? Has God ever taken such a support away, and can you now see grace in it?

Micah 5:9–13

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one “Bethlehem” in your life – a small task, a quiet faithfulness, a person others overlook – and give it your full attention this week, trusting that God works through small things.
- Identify one “horse” or “fortress” you lean on instead of God, and each day this week bring it to him in prayer, telling him honestly what you would fear if it were gone.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by worshipping Christ, the Ruler from Bethlehem, who stands and shepherds his people. Let each person name (aloud or silently) one place where they need his peace this week, and pray for each other: “Be this one's peace.” Close by asking that the group may be like dew from the LORD where they live and work.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 6

What the LORD Seeks

Micah 6:1–16

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time someone gave you a big present when what you really wanted was an apology or simply their time. How did it feel?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

With chapter 6 the last major section of Micah begins, and once again we are led into a courtroom. This time the LORD calls the mountains and the age-old hills as witnesses in his case against his people – yet he speaks not like an angry judge but like a wounded Father: “My people, what have I done to you?” Then the LORD's measuring line is carried from the hills into Jerusalem's market squares, where it finds false scales, violence and lies.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:1–1

[1] Hear, please, what the LORD says:
Get up, plead the case before the mountains,
and let the hills hear your voice!

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:2–3

2 Hear, you mountains, the case of the LORD,
you enduring ones, foundations of the earth!
For the LORD has a case against his people,
and with Israel he will argue it.
3 My people, what have I done to you?
How have I wearied you? Answer me!

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:4–4

4 For I brought you up from the land of Egypt,
and from the house of slaves I redeemed you;
and I sent before you
Moses, Aaron and Miriam.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:5–5

5 My people, remember
what Balak king of Moab planned,
and what Balaam son of Beor answered him –
from Shittim to Gilgal –
so that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:6–6

6 With what shall I come before the LORD,
and bow down before God on high?
Shall I come before him with burnt offerings,
with calves a year old?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:7–7

7 Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams,
with ten thousand rivers of oil?
Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion,
the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:8–8

8 He has told you, O man, what is good,
and what the LORD seeks from you:
only to do justice,
to love faithful love,
and to walk humbly with your God.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:9–10

9 The voice of the LORD calls out to the city –
and it is wisdom to see your name:
Hear the rod, and the one who appointed it!
10 Are there still in the house of the wicked
treasures of wickedness,
and the short measure that is cursed?

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:11–12

11 Can I count anyone pure with wicked scales
and with a bag of deceitful weights?
12 Her rich men are full of violence,
her inhabitants speak falsehood,
and their tongue is deceit in their mouth.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:13–14

13 So I too have begun to strike you,
to make you desolate because of your sins.
14 You will eat, but not be satisfied,
and the hunger will be inside you;
you will put things aside, but not save them,
and what you save I will give to the sword.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:15–15

15 You will sow, but not reap;
you will tread olives, but not anoint yourself with oil,
and grapes for new wine, but not drink wine.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 6:16–16

16 The statutes of Omri are kept,
and all the practices of the house of Ahab,
and you walk in their counsels;
so I will make you a desolation,
and her inhabitants something to hiss at;
and you will bear the reproach of my people.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְאַהֲבַת חֶסֶד

ahavat chesed · "to love faithful love"

Many English Bibles say "to love kindness" or "mercy", but literally the text says to love chesed: loyal covenant love, faithfulness, mercy and undeserved grace. It is the very word Micah uses for God himself at the end of the book (7:18, 20) – God asks us to love what he himself delights in.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

וְהַצְנֵעַ לֶכֶת

hatsnea' lekhet · "to walk humbly"

The rare verb tsana' occurs in the Old Testament only here and in Proverbs 11:2. It means walking with God humbly, attentively, without show and with a listening heart – not ahead of him in haste, not lagging behind, but with him.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חֻקּוֹת עָמְרִי

chuqqot 'omri · “the statutes of Omri”

The word chuqqot normally means the holy statutes of the LORD. With cutting irony, verse 16 says Judah keeps the “statutes” of Omri and Ahab instead – the unwritten rules of greed, abuse of power and religious compromise that brought prosperity to a few and ruin to the nation.

THE BIG IDEA

The LORD who redeemed his people cannot be bought with offerings; he has told us what is good – to do justice, to love faithful love and to walk humbly with our God – and he looks for it in the market, at the workbench and in our weighing of others.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Why do you think the LORD calls the mountains and hills as witnesses? And how is the tone of verse 3 different from what you would expect in a court case: “My people, what have I done to you? How have I wearied you? Answer me!”

Micah 6:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

In verses 4–5 the LORD answers the charge of “wearying” them by recalling Egypt, Balaam's blessing and the road from Shittim to Gilgal. Why does remembering what God has done drive out spiritual weariness? What is a “Shittim to Gilgal” moment in your own story?

Micah 6:4–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The worshipper in verses 6–7 keeps raising the price – calves, thousands of rams, rivers of oil, even “Shall I give my firstborn for my rebellion”. What picture of God lies behind these questions? In what modern ways do we try to “negotiate” with God?

Micah 6:6–7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“He has told you, O man, what is good.” Look at the three parts of verse 8. Why do they belong together, and what happens to each when one of the others is missing?

Micah 6:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Verse 8 asks us not only to show faithful love but to love it – the same chesed God delights in (7:18). What is the difference between doing kind things out of duty and loving faithful love?

Micah 6:8

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Can I count anyone pure with wicked scales and with a bag of deceitful weights?” Where do we handle “scales” today – at work, in money matters, or in the way we weigh other people's faults against our own?

Micah 6:10–12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Verses 14–15 describe eating without being satisfied and sowing without reaping. Where do you see this restless emptiness around you – or in yourself? What does verse 9 mean when it calls us to “Hear the rod, and the one who appointed it!”?

Micah 6:9–15

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose the one part of 6:8 that is most neglected in your life right now and take one concrete step in it this week – an honest correction, an act of faithful love, or ten quiet minutes walking with God.
- Check one “scale” in your life this week (your timesheet, an invoice, a promise, a judgement about someone) and make it honest.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by thanking God for the “righteous acts” he has done in your own lives. Then pray 6:8 for one another, each person naming the part they find hardest, and close by praying for honesty and justice in the places where group members work.

WHO IS A GOD LIKE YOU? · SESSION 7

Who Is a God Like You?

Micah 7:1–20

TO GET STARTED

Who is someone you could always count on as a child or teenager – and what made them so reliable?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 7 is the last, deeply personal movement of Micah. First the prophet walks like a hungry traveller through a stripped vineyard: there is no faithful one left, and even families have turned on each other (7:1–6). Then comes the turn – “But as for me, I will watch for the LORD” – and the book ends in a liturgy of repentance, hope and praise that asks the question behind Micah's own name and this whole series: “Who is a God like you?”

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:1–1

[1] Woe is me! For I have become
like one gathering summer fruit,
like one gleaning after the grape harvest:
there is no cluster to eat,
no early fig that my soul longs for.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:2–2

2 The faithful one has perished from the land,
and there is no one upright among people.
They all lie in wait for blood;
each hunts his brother with a net.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:3–3

3 Their hands are on evil, to do it well:
the official asks, and the judge – for a payment;
and the great man speaks out the craving of his soul;
and so they weave it together.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:4–4

4 The best of them is like a briar,
the most upright worse than a thorn hedge.
The day of your watchmen, your punishment, has come;
now their confusion will be.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:5–5

5 Do not trust a friend,
do not rely on a close companion;
from her who lies in your embrace
guard the doors of your mouth.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:6–6

6 For son treats father with contempt,
daughter rises up against her mother,
daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law;
a man's enemies are the people of his own house.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:7–7

7 But as for me, I will watch for the LORD;
I will wait for the God of my salvation;
my God will hear me.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:8–8

8 Do not rejoice over me, my enemy!
When I have fallen, I rise;
when I sit in darkness,
the LORD is light for me.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:9–9

9 The rage of the LORD I will bear,
for I have sinned against him,
until he pleads my case
and brings about justice for me.
He will bring me out into the light;
I will see his righteousness.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:10–10

10 And my enemy will see it,
and shame will cover her
who said to me: "Where is he, the LORD your God?"
My eyes will look on her;
now she will be trampled down
like mud in the streets.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:11–12

11 A day for building your walls!
On that day the boundary will be pushed far out.
12 On that day they will come to you,
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,
and from Egypt to the River,
from sea to sea and from mountain to mountain.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:13–13

13 But the earth will become a desolation
because of those who live in it,
as the fruit of their deeds.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:14–14

14 Shepherd your people with your staff,
the flock of your inheritance,
who live alone in a forest,
in the midst of a fruitful land;
let them graze in Bashan and Gilead
as in ancient days.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:15–16

15 As in the days when you came out of the land of Egypt,
I will show him wonders.
16 Nations will see and be ashamed
of all their might;
they will lay a hand on their mouth;
their ears will be deaf.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:17–17

17 They will lick dust like the snake,
like the creatures that crawl on the earth;
they will come trembling out of their strongholds;
to the LORD our God they will come in dread,
and they will fear you.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:18–18

18 Who is a God like you,
who bears away guilt
and passes over rebellion
for the remnant of his inheritance?
He does not hold on to his anger for ever,
for he delights in faithful love.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:19–19

19 He will again have compassion on us;
he will tread our guilt underfoot.
And you will cast all their sins
into the depths of the sea.

READ TOGETHER · MICAH 7:20–20

20 You will give truth to Jacob,
faithful love to Abraham,
as you swore to our fathers
from days of old.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חָסִיד

chasid · “the faithful one”

The word chasid comes straight from chesed, the faithful love the LORD asked for in 6:8. Because the people refused to love chesed, there is no chasid – no person of grace and faithfulness – left in the land (7:2).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

צָפָה

tsafah · “watch for”

Tsafah is the word for a watchman high on the city wall, shading his eyes and peering at the horizon for the coming of the king. Together with yachal, “wait” with eager expectation, it describes active, wakeful faith, not passive resignation (7:7).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

נֹשֵׂא עָוֹן

nose' 'awon · “bears away guilt”

Nasa' means to lift up and carry away, like the scapegoat on the Day of Atonement or the Lamb of God (John 1:29). It is the same verb as in verse 9, where Zion says she will bear the LORD's rage – and here God himself bears her guilt away (7:18).

THE BIG IDEA

When every human support collapses, the one who watches for the LORD finds that he hears, pleads our case and brings us into the light – for no one is like him: he bears away guilt, delights in faithful love and casts our sins into the depths of the sea.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Micah looks for one cluster of grapes, one early fig, one faithful person – and finds none (7:1–4). Where do you feel the same kind of disappointment today? What is the danger in that feeling?

Micah 7:1–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Verses 5–6 show the rot reaching the family itself; Jesus quotes verse 6 in Matthew 10:35–36. Why might faithfulness to Jesus sometimes bring tension even with those closest to us?

Micah 7:5–6

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“But as for me, I will watch for the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation; my God will hear me.” What does it look like in practice to “watch” like a watchman on the wall in a situation that has not yet been resolved?

Micah 7:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“When I have fallen, I rise; when I sit in darkness, the LORD is light for me.” Zion does not deny her sin (7:9). How does honest confession change God from the one who pleads a case against us (6:1–2) into the one who pleads our case?

Micah 7:8–10

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The staff that struck the ruler (4:14, English 5:1) and the rod over the city (6:9) become a shepherd's staff: “Shepherd your people with your staff.” What does this say about the purpose of God's discipline?

Micah 7:14

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Read verses 18–19 slowly. List what God does with our guilt, rebellion and sins. Which picture speaks most to you – and do you believe that he “delights in faithful love”, that he forgives gladly?

Micah 7:18–19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Is there a confessed sin you keep fishing up again, although God has cast it “into the depths of the sea”? And is there someone whose offence you are being called to let sink, as God has done for you?

Micah 7:19

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write 7:18–19 on a card and read it every morning this week. When an old, confessed failure comes back to mind, read it aloud and thank God that he has cast it into the sea.
- Think of one person you are holding something against. This week take one step towards passing over the offence – a prayer of blessing, a message, or a conversation.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a few moments of silent confession, then read 7:18–20 aloud together as a response. Let each person thank God in one sentence for one thing they have discovered about him in Micah, and close together with the question that names the series: “Who is a God like you?”